

S. UNNIKRISHNAN NAIR, 59

Director, Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre, Thiruvananthapuram

An expert in launch vehicle designs, Nair led the team that ensured ISRO's heavy lift launcher LVM3 put Chandrayaan-3 into the desired orbit. As founding director of the Human Space Flight Centre, he is playing a key role in the Gaganyaan project now. An alumnus of IISc and IIT Madras, Nair joined VSSC in 1985 and took over as director in 2022. He has also published short Malayalam stories.



NILESH M. DESAI, 59

Director, Space Applications Centre, Ahmedabad

Desai took charge of the SAC in 2021. ISRO's lead centre for the "design and development of space-borne instruments", SAC provided the Chandrayaan-3 lander imager cameras, Ka-band altimeter, hazard avoidance sensors and rover imagers along with their data processors. Desai is an engineering gold medallist from an Ahmedabad engineering university. He joined SAC straight out of college and became a specialist in microwave and radar systems.



B.N. RAMAKRISHNA, 58

Director, Telemetry, Tracking and Command Network Centre (ISTRAC), Bengaluru

ISRO's control centre for deep space missions, ISTRAC, headed by Ramakrishna, is the key communication link to all of ISRO's orbiting spacecraft, including the Chandrayaan. Ramakrishna has an M.Sc. and is an expert in orbit determination of spacecraft.



K. KALPANA, 49

Associate Project Director, Chandrayaan-3

Kalpana had dreamt of working with ISRO since childhood. After obtaining an engineering degree from a college in Chennai, she joined the space agency in 1999 as a radar engineer. She assisted Veeramuthuvel in the Chandrayaan-3 project and was closely associated with the Mangalyaan missions too.



V. NARAYANAN, 59

Director, Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre, Thiruvananthapuram

The LPSC, led by Narayanan, delivered the propulsion systems for the Vikram lander, including the thrusters for soft landing. A cryogenic engineering expert, he had chaired the panel that studied the crash of Chandrayaan-2's lander and recommended changes. Narayanan was born in Tamil Nadu, in Kanyakumari's Melakattuvilai village, to a farmer father. He has an engineering degree from the Govt. Polytechnic College, Nagercoil, and an M. Tech. and a Ph.D. in aerospace engineering from IIT Kharagpur.



ANIL BHARDWAJ, 56

Director, Physical Research Laboratory, Ahmedabad

A Ph.D.-holder in applied physics from IIT BHU, Bhardwaj headed the Space Physics Laboratory at VSSC before taking up his current post at PRL. He is a recipient of numerous awards, including the Bhatnagar Prize for scientists (2007) and the Infosys Prize (2016). The Chandrayaan-3 lander Vikram and its rover Pragyan, used to study the moon's surface, were developed by the PRL under his guidance.



M. SRIKANTH, 45

Mission Operations Director, Chandrayaan-3

M. Srikanth has been with ISRO for two decades. Hailing from Thiruvananthapuram, the B.Tech. graduate contributed to the Chandrayaan-1 and 2 missions. For Chandrayaan-3, he spearheaded the navigation aspect and was part of the planning and safety protocols.

S. MOHANA KUMAR, 59

Mission Director, LVM-3



It was S. Mohana Kumar, Chandrayaan-3's mission director, who first announced its successful launch on July 14 from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota, saying, "This is the result of the penance of many across ISRO centres." Kumar, who has been with ISRO for 30 years now, played a major role in the launch vehicles for Chandrayaan spacecraft and also led the launch of Oneweb India 2 satellites in March this year.